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Research Brief: Economic Report Influence Graph

Evidence-standard repair and expansion — 2026-07-29

1. What this is

There is a project that builds a directed graph of official economic reports. Nodes are real published releases — the Consumer Price Index, the Monetary Policy Report, a municipal tax rate bylaw. Edges mean **“this report uses or is derived from that report.”** The graph currently holds 120 reports and 192 dependencies, spanning Statistics Canada, the Bank of Canada, US federal statistical agencies, Alberta provincial fiscal documents, and two Alberta municipalities.

Your job is research. You will be asked to find **documents that prove specific dependencies exist**, and to say plainly when no such document exists.

You are not being asked to build anything, write code, or design anything. You are being asked to read primary sources carefully and report exactly what they say.

2. The one rule that matters

If no document explicitly names the source, the edge does not exist — however obvious the relationship looks.

This is the most important rule in the project and everything else is negotiable. It is worth understanding *why*, because the reason determines what counts as a good answer from you.

The graph’s whole value is that it is **auditable rather than plausible**. Anyone can guess that a central bank looks at unemployment data. The graph is only worth building if every edge in it can be traced to a document that says so, because otherwise it is just a diagram of one researcher’s assumptions with a veneer of authority.

The standard has a visible cost and **the cost is the point**. A real \$60-million-a-year Alberta funding programme is dropped from the graph on every build because no document names its inputs. A US Federal Reserve statistical release was dropped from the graph earlier today for the same reason. That is the standard working correctly, not a bug to be fixed.

What this means for you

A confident “no” is worth as much to us as a confident “yes.” More, sometimes. If you search hard and find nothing, that is a finding, it gets recorded permanently, and it stops the same question being asked again in three months.

A “yes” that turns out to be inference is the single worst outcome possible. It is worse than “no” and worse than silence, because it looks like progress and quietly poisons the thing that makes the project worth doing. If you are not sure, say you are not sure. You will not be penalised for it. You will be penalised for dressing an inference up as a citation.

Please do not try to be maximally helpful by finding *something* for every item. Several items on this list almost certainly have no document behind them. Finding that out is the job.

3. What counts as proof

Passes

- A **statute or regulation** naming a series or release by name. This is the strongest evidence available and is usually findable. Example, real, from this project: Canada Pension Plan Regulations s.75(1) — *“the Pension Index for each year shall be calculated as the quotient obtained by dividing the aggregate of the Consumer Price Index for each month in the 12-month period ending October 31 in the preceding year by 12.”* That is proof.
- A **methodology handbook or technical annex** stating what source data a release uses. Example: the BEA NIPA Handbook naming the Census Bureau’s Monthly Retail Trade Survey as source data for PCE.
- A **formal agreement** that defines one thing in terms of another. Example: the 2021 Joint Statement of the Government of Canada and the Bank of Canada — *“the target will continue to be defined in terms of the 12-month rate of change in the total CPI.”*
- A **release stating its own composition** in its own documentation.
- A **footnote or source line naming a specific release or publisher** for a specific series. Example: the Fed’s H.15 footnotes 9 and 10, both reading *“Source: U.S. Treasury”* against the constant maturity series.

Fails

- **Naming an agency instead of a release.** A chart sourced *“Statistics Canada”* does not establish that the Labour Force Survey specifically was used. Statistics Canada publishes hundreds of releases. This distinction has already cost this project real edges and it is the single most common way to get an item wrong.
- **A webpage saying two things are “related”, “linked to”, or “influenced by”.** Too vague. A regulation naming a series is evidence; a page saying two things go together is not.
- **Reasoning from how the world works.** “Central banks obviously monitor employment data” is not evidence, no matter how true it is.
- **A third party describing the relationship.** A news article, a think tank paper, or an encyclopedia saying that X uses Y does not count. It must be the publisher of X saying so, or a statute binding X.
- **Your own synthesis across two documents.** If document A says X uses “labour market data” and document B says the LFS is the main labour market data source, that is two facts and an inference, not a citation. Report it as a near-miss if you like, clearly labelled — but it does not pass.

The hardest and most useful distinction

Publishers differ in how much they disclose, and that difference is **a fact about the publisher, not a gap in the research.** A statutory formula listing four enumerated inputs and a central

bank that deliberates over a broad information set are genuinely different kinds of thing. If the honest answer for an item is *"this body does not disclose its inputs at that level of specificity, and here is the closest it comes,"* that is an excellent answer. Say it.

4. Vocabulary

If you do find evidence, say which of these four the document supports. They are ordered strongest to weakest and the choice is a judgement about what the document actually says, not a formality.

Type	Meaning
calculated_from	The output is mechanically derived from the target. Arithmetic.
uses_data_from	The target's figures are a direct input, but not by formula.
methodology_depends_on	The target defines a method, classification or deflator the source relies on.
cites	Referenced as context, not as a computational input.

A real worked example from the project: the Canadian Bank Rate is `calculated_from` the policy rate, because it is defined as the policy rate plus 25 basis points — arithmetic. The chartered bank prime rate only `uses_data_from` the policy rate, because the Bank of Canada's own word for the relationship is *"affects."* Same two institutions, different strength, and the difference came from reading what the Bank actually wrote.

5. How to report

For **every** item, whether you succeed or fail, return this shape. Plain text is fine. Consistency matters more than beauty, because these get processed mechanically.

ITEM: <the item number and edge, exactly as given>

VERDICT: DOCUMENTED | NOT-FOUND | CONTRADICTED | WRONG-AS-STATED

If DOCUMENTED:

URL: <direct link to the document, deep-linked if possible>
DOCUMENT: <title, publisher, date or version>
QUOTE: "<verbatim sentence(s) proving it – do not paraphrase>"
LOCATION: <section number, page, footnote, chart number>
TYPE: `calculated_from` | `uses_data_from` | `methodology_depends_on` | `cites`
TIMING: <if the document states when the reading happens – e.g. "12 months ending September 30", "the July 1 estimate", "third quarter average". Skip if not stated. Do not infer.>

If NOT-FOUND:

SEARCHED: <every document you actually opened, with URLs – this is the valuable part, do not abbreviate it>
CLOSEST: <the nearest thing any of them said, quoted, and why it falls short>
ASSESSMENT: <is this a publisher who does not disclose at this level, or a document you could not get to? These are different and the

difference matters.>

If CONTRADICTED:

<a document positively states the relationship does NOT hold, or holds differently. Quote it. This is a high-value result.>

If WRONG-AS-STATED:

<the relationship is real but runs to a different release, or in the opposite direction, or via an intermediate. Say what the correct version is and prove that instead.>

Verbatim quotes are mandatory for anything you mark DOCUMENTED. If you cannot quote it, it is not documented. Please do not tidy up the wording of quotes.

6. ROUND 1 — The core task: 14 unproven edges

These 14 edges are currently in the graph and **none of them has a supporting document**. They are the last thing blocking the project from expanding, and they are concentrated in the monetary-policy core of both countries.

Each is stated below as a **claim to be tested, not a fact to be confirmed**. The claim text is what a previous researcher asserted without proof. Several are probably wrong. Two similar edges were deleted earlier today after checking:

- One claimed the Fed's H.15 release reports the FOMC's target range. **It does not** — H.15 carries no target-range series at all, and its only federal funds line is sourced to an administrative reporting form (FR 2420).
- One claimed the FOMC Statement uses the CPI. The FOMC's target is PCE-based, a properly evidenced edge to PCE already existed, and nothing supported the CPI claim.

So: **treat every claim below as a hypothesis**. Disproving one is a win.

Group A — Statistics Canada internal (2)

1. statcan-national-accounts → statcan-gdp-monthly — proposed uses_data_from Claim: *"The quarterly expenditure-based accounts are reconciled against the monthly by-industry GDP estimates."* Source: National Economic Accounts (Quarterly), Statistics Canada Target: Gross Domestic Product by Industry (Monthly), Statistics Canada Where to look: StatCan's *Guide to the Income and Expenditure Accounts*, the National Economic Accounts methodology documentation, the survey pages for record numbers 1901 and 1301.

2. statcan-national-accounts → statcan-cpi — proposed methodology_depends_on Claim: *"Consumer expenditure components are deflated to real terms using CPI price detail."* Where to look: the same guide, specifically the chapters on deflation and volume measures. Note the trap — the accounts may use a CPI-derived deflator rather than the CPI itself, and if the document says so, that is a WRONG-AS-STATED result worth having.

Group B — Bank of Canada policy rate (2)

3. boc-policy-rate → statcan-lfs — proposed uses_data_from Claim: *"Labour market slack from the LFS is a standing input to the rate decision."* Known obstacle, stated so you do not waste time: the 2021 Joint Statement commits the Bank to considering *"a broad range of labour market indicators"* and to *"systematically report to Canadians on how labour market outcomes have factored into its monetary policy decisions."* **It does not name the Labour Force Survey.** That is the near-miss. The question is whether anything else does — a methodology note, an MPR chart source line, a technical box, a *Summary of Governing Council Deliberations*.

4. boc-policy-rate → statcan-national-accounts — proposed uses_data_from Claim: *“Output gap assessment rests on the quarterly national accounts.”* Where to look: the Bank’s output gap / potential output methodology publications, the *Indicators of Capacity and Inflation Pressures* page.

Group C — Bank of Canada Monetary Policy Report (4)

boc-mpr is the **highest-value target in this whole brief**. It is currently the only node in the graph that vanishes entirely when the evidence standard is applied strictly — all six of its edges are unproven. One good document could rescue the entire node.

5. boc-mpr → statcan-cpi — proposed uses_data_from Claim: *“The MPR inflation projection is stated in CPI terms.”*

6. boc-mpr → statcan-lfs — proposed uses_data_from Claim: *“Labour market conditions chapter draws directly on the LFS.”*

7. boc-mpr → statcan-national-accounts — proposed uses_data_from Claim: *“GDP projections are anchored to the quarterly national accounts.”*

8. boc-mpr → boc-policy-rate — proposed cites Claim: *“The MPR is published alongside and explains the accompanying rate decision.”*

For all four: the MPR itself is the document. Recent issues are at bankofcanada.ca/publications/mpr/. Go into an actual issue — the PDF is better than the landing page — and read the **chart and table source lines**, the projection tables, and any technical boxes. Be strict with yourself here: *“Sources: Statistics Canada and Bank of Canada calculations”* names an agency, not a release, and does **not** prove items 6 or 7. If that is all you find, say so — that is a legitimate and useful NOT-FOUND with a precise reason.

Group D — US Federal Reserve (4)

9. fed-fomc-statement → bls-employment-situation — proposed uses_data_from Claim: *“The employment half of the dual mandate is assessed from this release.”*

10. fed-fomc-statement → bea-gdp — proposed uses_data_from Claim: *“Assessment of economic activity rests on the NIPA GDP estimates.”*

11. fed-sep → bls-employment-situation — proposed uses_data_from Claim: *“SEP unemployment rate projections are stated on the household survey basis.”*

12. fed-sep → bea-gdp — proposed uses_data_from Claim: *“SEP growth projections are stated as real GDP change.”*

Where to look: the *Statement on Longer-Run Goals and Monetary Policy Strategy*; the **SEP’s own table footnotes and the “Notes” section**, which define precisely what each projected variable means — this is the most promising single source for items 11 and 12; the FOMC projections FAQ; the Fed’s *Monetary Policy Report to Congress*. For item 11 specifically, check whether the SEP defines the unemployment rate projection in terms of the **Current Population Survey** rather than the Employment Situation release — the CPS is already a separate node in this graph (cps-current-population-survey), so that would be a WRONG-AS-STATED with a ready-made correct target.

Group E — Cross-border (2)

These two matter structurally. The project has measured that there are **zero standard-compliant direct official links between the Canadian and US statistical systems** — the only compliant cross-border link in the entire graph is a commodity futures price. Proving either of these would be the first.

13. boc-mpr → fed-fomc-statement — proposed cites Claim: *“The MPR conditions its projection on the expected path of US monetary policy.”*

14. boc-mpr → bea-gdp — proposed cites Claim: *“US growth is treated as an explicit external assumption in the MPR projection.”*

Where to look: the MPR’s external assumptions table — most issues have one, often listing US GDP growth, oil prices and the exchange rate as conditioning assumptions. If that table names its sources, items 13 and 14 are settled. If it gives figures without attribution, that is a precise and valuable NOT-FOUND.

7. ROUND 2 — Missing nodes that reconnect the graph

Here the task changes: **research a release well enough that it can become a node**, and prove at least one edge to something already in the graph.

For a new node, report: official title, publisher, a stable URL, how many times a year it is published, and what it is. Then prove its edges as in Round 1.

2a. US Treasury daily yield curve / interest rate statistics — HIGH PRIORITY. The Fed’s H.15 release was dropped from the graph today and currently does not exist in it. H.15’s footnotes 9 and 10 both say *“Source: U.S. Treasury”* for the Treasury constant maturity series, and state those yields are *“interpolated by the U.S. Treasury from the daily yield curve.”* So the evidence already exists — what is missing is the Treasury release as a node. Research it and H.15 comes back.

2b. Canada Community-Building Fund. The City of Grande Prairie’s 2026 budget names it as a capital source at \$5,160,000. The federal programme has never been researched. Per-capita allocation, documented formula.

2c. Public Accounts of Alberta. CIHI’s National Health Expenditure Trends states: *“For the provincial/territorial government sector, data is extracted annually from the public accounts of provincial/territorial governments.”* The edge is documented; the node does not exist.

2d. Finance Canada economic and fiscal projections. The *Actuarial Report on the Employment Insurance Premium Rate* says at s.4.2.2 of the unemployment rate assumption: *“This assumption is provided by the Minister of Finance.”* It names no specific published document. Find out whether one exists.

2e. US Basel implementation. The Federal Reserve maintains a Basel Regulatory Framework page and US capital rules are Basel-derived. The Canadian half of this chain is in the graph and the American half is missing.

2f. Grande Spirit Foundation requisition. Grande Prairie Bylaw C-1486 levies \$1,030,421 for this seniors housing management body. No stable published landing page for its annual requisition has been found. Determine whether one exists.

8. ROUND 3 — Leads where the evidence is already believed to exist

These are recorded in the project as *“evidence described as existing, node or pass missing.”* They should be faster than Round 1. Same output format.

3a. bls-employment-situation → uscensus-population-estimates. The household side comes from the CPS, whose estimates are controlled to independent population estimates. The **CPS methodology documentation** has never been read. Confirm and quote.

3b. bea-pce → Census Bureau retail and services surveys. NIPA Handbook Chapter 5 reportedly names the Annual Retail Trade Survey, Service Annual Survey, Quarterly Services Survey and

Monthly Retail Trade Survey as principal source data for current-dollar PCE. Verify and quote each.

3c. bls-cpi → USPS Household Diary Survey, and bls-cpi → DOT airline origin-destination database. Both named in the BLS Handbook of Methods alongside J.D. Power. Quote the passages.

3d. Variable mortgage rates → boc-prime-rate. Variable mortgage rates are quoted as prime plus or minus a spread — the last link between a central bank decision and a household payment. The Bank publishes an explainer on what is behind a mortgage rate. Find whether any document states this as a formula.

3e. gp-tax-rate-by-law → opted-out school board. Both Grande Prairie municipal bylaws levy an “*Opted Out School Board*” requisition without naming the board. Find a document that names which board this is. Do not infer it from local knowledge — that is exactly what the standard excludes.

9. ROUND 4 — Expansion: the Equalization formula

This is the largest single expansion the project could make, and it is well evidenced. Equalization already exists as a node (fiscal-equalization-program) with exactly one edge, making it a leaf. It should be a hub.

The formula lives in the **Federal-Provincial Fiscal Arrangements Act and its Regulations**, and reportedly names the **Representative Tax System** bases explicitly: personal income, business income, consumption, and property tax bases, each with a defined Statistics Canada source.

Task: work through the Act and Regulations and extract, with quotes and section numbers, **every statistical series the formula names as an input**. For each, state whether it corresponds to a node already in the graph — several should, including statcan-population-estimates, statcan-national-accounts and statcan-cpi.

This connects every Canadian province to the same handful of national statistics, which is why it ranks above everything else in the expansion backlog.

If Round 4 goes well, the adjacent targets are Territorial Formula Financing, Fiscal Stabilization, and the Canada Health and Social Transfer escalators.

10. Existing node identifiers

Please attach every proposed edge to an identifier from this list where one exists, rather than inventing a new name for something already present. Batches of research that invent their own identifiers produce disconnected islands, which is a failure mode this project has hit before.

Canada — federal (39): boc-bank-rate, boc-corra, boc-daily-exchange-rates, boc-mortgage-qualifying-rate, boc-mpr, boc-policy-rate, boc-posted-chartered-bank-rates, boc-prime-rate, canada-child-benefit, canada-health-transfer, canada-social-transfer, cdic-differential-premiums-manual, cmhc-mortgage-loan-insurance, cmhc-residential-mortgage-industry-report, cpp-disability-amount, cpp-pension-index, cpp-ympe, cra-indexation-adjustment, dof-insured-mortgage-qualifying-rules, ei-actuarial-report-premium-rate, ei-maximum-insurable-earnings, ei-premium-rate, ei-regional-unemployment-rates, ei-regular-benefit-rate, esdc-oas-indexation, fiscal-equalization-program, osfi-b20, osfi-car-guideline, osfi-mqr-uninsured, statcan-census-population, statcan-cpi, statcan-cpi-basket-update, statcan-gdp-monthly, statcan-hfce, statcan-lfs, statcan-national-accounts, statcan-population-estimates, statcan-seph, statcan-shs

Canada — provincial, Alberta (28): ab-aadl-cost-share, ab-adult-health-benefit-income-levels, ab-aish-benefit-rates, ab-bvm-components, ab-child-family-benefit, ab-continuing-care-accommodation-charges, ab-dip-requisition, ab-education-funding-manual, ab-education-property-tax-requisition, ab-education-student-enrolment, ab-gas-reference-price, ab-income-support-rates, ab-mrf-guidelines, ab-municipalaffairs-equalized-assessment, ab-municipalaffairs-financial-statistical-data, ab-municipalaffairs-fir, ab-municipalaffairs-lgff-capital, ab-municipalaffairs-population-list, ab-oil-par-prices, ab-oilsands-royalty-rates, ab-regulated-property-guidelines, ab-seniors-benefit-rates, ab-tbf-alberta-escalator, ab-tbf-economic-outlook, ab-tbf-fiscal-plan, ab-tbf-fiscal-update, ab-tbf-population-estimates, aer-general-well-data

Canada — municipal (10): cgp-assessment-roll, cgp-budget, cgp-financial-statements, cgp-municipal-census, cgp-tax-rate-by-law, gp-assessment-roll, gp-budget, gp-financial-statements, gp-municipal-census, gp-tax-rate-by-law

Canada — institutional (8): ahs-business-plan, ahs-financial-statements, cihi-nhex, gppsd-budget, gppsd-financial-statements, grande-spirit-requisition, psab-psas, term-corra

United States — federal (22): bea-gdp, bea-pce, bls-c-cpi-u, bls-cex, bls-cpi, bls-employment-situation, bls-qcew, cps-current-population-survey, fed-fomc-statement, fed-h8, fed-sep, fed-z1, ffiec-call-report, hhs-poverty-guidelines, irs-annual-inflation-adjustments, ssa-cola, ssa-contribution-benefit-base, ssa-national-average-wage-index, ssa-pia-formula, uscensus-decennial, uscensus-population-estimates, uscensus-poverty-thresholds

International (9): bis-basel-framework, cpi-manual, icls-work-statistics-resolution, imf-bpm6, imf-gfsm, ipsas, naics, sna-2008, un-census-principles

Commercial, published but not official (4): jd-power-valuation-services, nymex-wti-settlement-prices, ice-brent-futures-settlement, argus-mexico-maya-spot

11. A note on sources you may be tempted to use

You may have access to social media, and it is worth being direct about where that helps here and where it does not.

It mostly does not. Central banks, statistical agencies and finance ministries post announcements constantly, and an announcement is not a methodology. A Bank of Canada post saying the policy rate has changed does not establish what fed into the decision, and citing it as though it did would fail this brief in the most damaging way available. The same goes for commentary from economists, journalists and officials, however well-informed — under the rule in section 2, a third party describing a relationship is not evidence of it.

Where it might genuinely help: as a *finding aid*. Agencies often post direct links to methodology documents, technical annexes, consultation papers and regulatory changes that are hard to surface through ordinary search. If a post leads you to a primary document, follow it to that document, read it, and cite the document — never the post. Announcements of methodology changes are the most plausible use, since those are exactly the documents that name inputs.

The same logic applies to news articles, blogs, and reference sites: useful for finding your way to a primary source, never a substitute for one.

12. How this will be assessed

So you know what a good response looks like:

1. **Correctness of DOCUMENTED verdicts.** Every quote will be checked against the URL you give. A quote that does not appear at that URL, or that does not actually support the claim, is the most serious error possible here — more serious than getting nothing at all.

2. **Quality of NOT-FOUND verdicts.** A NOT-FOUND that lists the documents opened, quotes the closest near-miss, and says why it falls short is a complete result and will be recorded permanently. A bare “could not find it” is nearly worthless, because the next person repeats the work.
3. **Willingness to disprove.** CONTRADICTED and WRONG-AS-STATED verdicts are the highest-value outcomes in this brief. Two of the original 21 edges were deleted today for exactly these reasons. If you find a third, that is a better result than three confirmations.
4. **Coverage.** Round 1 matters most. Round 4 is the largest prize. Rounds 2 and 3 are in between. Partial results are welcome — please report per item as you go rather than holding everything back for one complete answer at the end.

If you can only do part of this, **do Round 1**, and within Round 1 prioritise Group C — the Monetary Policy Report is one document that could settle four edges and rescue a node.

13. Summary of the ask

- **14 edges** in Round 1, each stated as a hypothesis, several probably false.
- **6 missing nodes** in Round 2, one of which restores a release that just fell out of the graph.
- **5 leads** in Round 3 where the evidence is believed to already exist.
- **1 statutory formula** in Round 4 that could connect every Canadian province to the same national statistics.

Verbatim quotes with URLs and section numbers for anything you mark DOCUMENTED. Full search trails for anything you mark NOT-FOUND. Disprove whatever you can.